The F-1 Student to Green Card 5-Year Roadmap

How International Graduates Strategically Transition from Degree to Permanent Residency

- Over 1,000,000 international students study in the U.S. on F-1 visas.
- Navigating CPT, OPT, STEM OPT, and immigrant petitions requires multi-year planning.
- Relying on a single lottery pool is the #1 mistake graduates make.
- A multi-track statutory strategy guarantees continuous lawful status.

KEY TAKEAWAY / ACTION:

Plan your immigration timeline starting from your first academic semester.

Years 1 & 2: CPT & Degree Milestone Strategy

Maximizing Curricular Practical Training While Preserving OPT

- **CPT Rule:**
  Must complete 1 full academic year before eligible for off-campus CPT.
- **Preserving OPT:**
  Keep full-time CPT under 12 cumulative months to protect your 12 months of Post-Completion OPT.
- **Employer Selection:**
  Target E-Verify employers with documented history of sponsoring STEM extensions and permanent residency.

KEY TAKEAWAY / ACTION:

Full-time CPT over 364 days automatically cancels all subsequent OPT!

Year 3: Post-Completion OPT Execution

Mastering the 12-Month Window & Strict Unemployment Tracking

- **Filing Window:**
  Apply 90 days before graduation to 60 days after graduation.
- **Unemployment Clock:**
  You have a strict cumulative limit of 90 unemployment days.
- **Employment Verification:**
  Work must be directly related to your major field of study.
- **First H-1B Attempt:**
  Enter the March/April lottery during your initial OPT year.

KEY TAKEAWAY / ACTION:

Volunteer or research work (20+ hrs/wk) can stop the unemployment clock.

Years 4 & 5: STEM OPT 24-Month Extension

Leveraging 3 Full Years of Total Lawful U.S. Work Authorization

- **Form I-983:**
  Complete the formal Training Plan with your E-Verify employer.
- **Unemployment Buffer:**
  Grants an additional 60 days of allowed unemployment (150 total).
- **Multiple Lottery Shots:**
  Gives candidates up to 3 total attempts in the annual lottery.
- **Parallel Path:**
  Ideal window to build evidence for an EB-2 NIW self-petition.

KEY TAKEAWAY / ACTION:

Never wait until the final STEM year to initiate Green Card discussions.

The Dual-Track Strategy: Bypassing the Lottery

What to Do If the H-1B Lottery Does Not Select Your Petition

- **Option A:**
  Cap-Exempt H-1B transfer with university research or hospital network.
- **Option B:**
  Self-petition EB-2 NIW (National Interest Waiver) or O-1 Extraordinary Ability.
- **Option C:**
  Day 1 CPT at an accredited university while continuing full-time work.
- **Option D:**
  Global remote work (Form W-8BEN) while waiting for consular filing.

KEY TAKEAWAY / ACTION:

Smart candidates always have an active Plan B running in parallel.

Top 4 Status Traps That Ruin F-1 Trajectories

Avoid Critical SEVIS and USCIS Adjudication Pitfalls

- **Trap 1:**
  Miscalculating the 60-day post-OPT grace period departure window.
- **Trap 2:**
  Traveling internationally while Form I-765 (EAD) is pending adjudication.
- **Trap 3:**
  Exceeding the 90-day (OPT) or 150-day (STEM) unemployment limit in SEVIS.
- **Trap 4:**
  Working in a role not directly documented in your academic coursework.

■ KEY TAKEAWAY / ACTION:

Calculate your exact filing windows on our free calculator.

Your Complete F-1 Status Diagnostic Toolkit

Plan Your Career with Verifiable Statutory Intelligence

- STEM OPT Grace Period & Unemployment Countdown Calculator.
- Cap-Exempt Institutional Sponsor Directory (365-day non-lottery roles).
- EB-2 NIW Dhanasar Self-Petition Diagnostic Scorer.
- Verified U.S. Job Board with direct corporate visa sponsorship filters.

■ KEY TAKEAWAY / ACTION:

Access all tools for free: uscareersolutions.online/tools